ASSISTANT MANAGER ESSENTIALS: LEVEL 1

Assistant Manager Essentials: Level 1 — Level 1: Assistant Manager Essentials — Day 3: Leading People

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1: Assistant Manager Essentials · Day 3: Leading People

How to Use This Guide

You lead people from today. Not from the day you get the title, and not from the day someone hands you a team list. From the day a colleague takes a piece of work from you, waits on your answer, or watches how you handle a slip. That is where leadership starts, and it is where this guide starts too.

Read the sections in order. They build on each other: clear expectations first, then check-ins, then feedback, then recognition, then holding a boundary. Write your answers to the reflection prompts as you go, before you read the model answers at the end. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

This is Day 3 of five. Yesterday you learned to run the day; today you learn to lead the people in it. Keep your real work list open next to this guide. You will use it.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the four parts of a clear expectation, what a short one-to-one check-in is for, and the three steps of SBI and A.R.T.

Attitude: You will accept that most missed commitments are an expectation problem before they are a people problem, and that holding a boundary is a kindness to the whole team.

Skill: You will be able to set an expectation in under a minute, run a fifteen-minute one-to-one that actually listens, give feedback on a missed commitment with SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact), and hold a boundary with A.R.T.

Upskill: You will hold that boundary when the person pushes back twice, without escalating the tone and without giving away the standard.

Setting Expectations That Stick

An expectation is not a request. A request leaves room for guessing: when is it due, who needs it, what happens if it slips. Most people who miss a deadline were never clear on all three. The gap was created before they started.

A clear expectation has four parts. Say them in this order.

The result: what "done" looks like, described as something you could look at. "The list cleaned, with every open item assigned to a name" beats "get that sorted".

The time: a date or a day and an hour, not "soon" or "when you can".

Who depends on it: the person or team waiting on the output, and what they will do with it. People protect other people's work more carefully than they protect an abstract deadline.

What to do if it slips: the instruction that makes the other parts safe. "If you can see this going past Thursday, tell me Wednesday, not Friday." You are giving them permission to report early, and telling them exactly how.

Why does the fourth part matter so much? Because people avoid bad news. Nobody enjoys telling the person who assigned them work that the work is late. So they wait, hoping to catch up, and the

news arrives worse. When you name the moment for the bad news in advance, and make clear that reporting it is the behavior you want, you shift the cost. Early reporting stops feeling like an admission and starts feeling like doing the job.

The psychology here is worth holding on to. A person told to raise a problem early can keep a picture of themselves as honest and reliable. A person with no such instruction faces a choice between admitting failure and staying quiet. The quiet option is easier, and they take it.

> **NOTES**
>
> Vague time words are the most common leak. "By end of play" and "as soon as you can" mean different things to you and to them.

One-to-One Check-Ins That Listen

A one-to-one is not a status meeting. Status you can get in a written update. The one-to-one exists for the things a written update never carries: what is getting harder, what the person is unsure about, what they are angry about, what they want next.

Keep it short and keep it regular. Fifteen minutes, same day each week or two, holds better than an hour squeezed in once a month. Short and frequent gives small problems time to surface before they are big.

Open with a real question. "What is taking more effort than it should right now?" is better than "any issues?" because it assumes nothing and invites detail. Then listen, and stop talking.

This is harder than it sounds. Most people cannot sit through a few seconds of silence, and they fill it by answering their own question, offering a solution, or moving on. When you do that, the person stops giving you the real answer, because the real answer takes longer to reach. Let them reach it. If you must speak, ask one more question.

What you are building is small and cumulative. Every check-in where you listen and do not judge is a small deposit; every check-in where you take the conversation over is a withdrawal. Trust works like an emotional bank account: kept promises and courtesies are deposits, letdowns are withdrawals. A person who has seen you listen will tell you about a slip two days early. A person who has not seen you listen will not.

A short practical structure: one question about workload, one about blockers, one about something they want to improve or learn, and one close. End by repeating back what you agreed, and who does what, so nothing depends on memory.

Practice example: In a warehouse team in a busy season, a team member tells their Assistant Manager the pick list is taking longer than it should because two items need a second check. The Assistant Manager asks, "What would make the second check faster without changing the standard?" The team member suggests pairing the check with a fixed point in the shift. That is a solution the Assistant Manager would never have found alone, and it came from one question and eight seconds of silence.

Feedback on a Missed Commitment: SBI

A missed commitment needs feedback. Not a lecture, not a shrug, and not the same message sent to everyone in the team. The person needs to know exactly what happened, why it mattered, and what changes.

Use SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact; Center for Creative Leadership). It is a feedback model in three parts: describe the specific Situation, the observable Behavior and its Impact. Specific, factual feedback is easier to hear and act on.

Part one, the situation: name the time and the task. "In Tuesday's shift handover, the closing checklist for the evening order." Part two, the behavior: say what you saw or heard, not what you concluded. "Two lines were left without a confirmation, and the checklist was not signed." Part three, the impact: say what it caused or could have caused, for real. "The morning team had to re-check both lines and started their own work late."

Then stop and ask a question. "What happened from your side?" Now the person can speak, and you can learn whether this is a skill, a habit, a workload issue, or something you set up badly. You may discover the expectation was never clear, in which case part of this feedback belongs to you. Say so.

SBI ends with the impact. What follows is a separate step: agree the next behavior and have the person practice it. Not "try harder", but "walk me through how you will run the last ten minutes of the next handover". Keep that practice step distinct from SBI itself, so the model stays clean and the person knows exactly which part is feedback and which part is the plan.

Why does the structure work? Because character feedback triggers a defense: the person hears "you are careless", and their whole mind goes to defending who they are. Behavior feedback describes something they can change and leaves their identity alone. Keep the words about what you observed. "The checklist was not signed" is feedback. "You are sloppy" is not.

> **NOTES**
>
> Keep it prompt. Days between the event and the conversation make it feel like a formal complaint rather than a coaching moment.

Recognition That Lands

Recognition works the same way as corrective feedback and is far more often bungled. Name the behavior and its impact, promptly and in specific terms. "Yesterday you flagged the supply delay at the start of the shift instead of waiting. Because of that the customer got a new date before they asked." That tells the person exactly what to repeat.

Vague praise does nothing, and general praise handed to a whole team for one person's effort teaches people that effort does not show. Be specific, be quick, and sometimes be quiet about it: a short word in private is often valued more than an announcement.

The psychology is simple and worth knowing. Specific recognition gives people a picture of themselves as competent in a defined way. They then act to keep that picture true. General praise gives no picture at all.

Holding a Boundary When Someone Pushes Back

Now the hardest part of leading people: someone asks for an exception you cannot give. A deadline moved, a standard skipped, a task dropped. It might be a reasonable request from a tired person. It still gets a boundary.

The common mistake is to re-explain the rule. You explain the process again, in more detail, faster. The person pushes harder, because now they feel unheard as well as blocked. Pressure creates resistance; pushing a person toward an answer makes them grip their own position tighter.

Use A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework for handling pushback and concerns, developed by Steven Saad: Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition. In this guide it is adapted to a team member rather than a customer.

Acknowledge: label the person's feeling, and put no "but" after it. "It sounds like the deadline has left you with more on your plate than you can carry." Acknowledging a feeling calms it (Lieberman et al., 2007). When someone feels heard, the need to keep proving their point drops away.

Reframe: shift the decision criterion from what they want changed to what changing it would cost. Do not re-explain the rule. "If we move the date, the next team works late on Monday, and the customer's schedule moves too." You are not refusing the feeling; you are showing the other side of the trade.

Transition: ask a calibrated how or what question (Voss & Raz, 2016). "What would make the current date workable?" or "How would you want the two of us to explain a changed date to the team on Monday?" It hands the person the next move, keeps agency with them, and does not give the boundary away.

Practice example: A team member asks to log their customer calls the next morning instead of on the day, after a long day of visits. The Assistant Manager acknowledges: "You are running flat out, and the idea of one more log tonight feels too much." Reframes: "When the log is filled a day later, the person covering on a sick day reads old notes and calls the wrong people." Transitions: "What would make a same-day log realistic for you on a day like this?" And when they push again, hold the same three steps, calmly, in a steady voice. Your voice matters here. A steady, slightly slower pace sounds confident (Guyer et al., 2019) and keeps the tone from rising.

If the person is not accepting the boundary, that is a fact, not a feeling. Say it plainly. "I hear you, and the same-day log stays. What would help you make it work?" If the issue touches something outside your authority, this is where Day 1's own, escalate, document applies: escalate early with a recommendation, and tell the person you are doing it. Escalating is a strength, not a failure.

Apply It in Your Role

You do not need the title to start. If you have no team of your own yet, use the people you already work with: a colleague who takes a task from you, a new starter, a peer in a shared project. That is your practice ground.

- ☐ Set one expectation today, using all four parts: result, time, who depends on it, what to do if it slips. Write it in two sentences and send it or say it.

- ☐ Put one fifteen-minute check-in in your calendar for the same day next week. Send the invitation today.
- ☐ Choose one recent missed commitment. Write the SBI feedback in three lines, one per part, and delete any word about character.
- ☐ Give one piece of specific recognition this week, within a day of the behavior.
- ☐ Practice your A.R.T. chain out loud. Say Acknowledge, Reframe and Transition as one flow, so it sounds like one person speaking, not three steps.

Reflection: Which of these will be hardest for you, and why? Write it down before you try. Naming the discomfort before you act on it tends to make the act easier.

> **NOTES**
>
> If your manager asks what you are doing, tell them. You are not going behind anyone's back; you are building the habit early, with their eyes on it.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you read the model answers. Keep it to a few lines. Then compare, and note what you would change.

1. A colleague you rely on has not delivered the stock count you agreed for Monday. It is now Wednesday and the customer proposal goes out Friday.

2. A team member arrives at a check-in and says they have nothing to talk about. You suspect a problem is building.

3. A colleague asks you to relax a safety check "just this once", because the customer is waiting. You have no authority to change the check.

Key Takeaways

Expectations fail at the setting stage more often than at the doing stage. Name the result, the time, who depends on it, and the moment to report a slip.

Permission to report early changes what is easy for people to do. It lets them stay honest without losing face.

Short, regular check-ins find problems while they are still small. Ask one real question, then let the silence work. Trust builds like an emotional bank account, where kept promises are deposits and letdowns are withdrawals (Covey, 1989).

Use SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) for feedback: specific, observable, prompt. SBI has three parts, and asking the person to practice the next behavior is a separate step that follows it. Describe behavior, never the person.

Recognition is specific and prompt, and it names the behavior and the impact.

A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework for handling pushback and concerns, runs in three steps: Acknowledge the feeling with no "but", Reframe from the demand to the cost of changing, and Transition with a calibrated how or what question. It is not a trade and not a concession.

Quiz

Choose the best answer for each question.

1. Which set makes an expectation complete?
   - **A.** A clear result and a clear deadline
   - **B.** A result, a time, who depends on it, and what to do if it slips
   - **C.** A result, a warning about consequences, and the standard
   - **D.** A deadline, a reminder, and your own promise to check
2. A colleague has just told you about a slip for the first time, three days late. What is the best first response?
   - **A.** Tell them the lateness is unacceptable before anything else
   - **B.** Ask why they did not come to you sooner
   - **C.** Acknowledge the situation, get the facts, and agree how to report and fix it early
   - **D.** Take the task off them and do it yourself
3. How is SBI best used on a missed commitment?
   - **A.** Describe the situation, the observable behavior and the impact, then practice the next behavior
   - **B.** Describe the pattern across months and ask them to explain it
   - **C.** Say what you would have done differently in their place
   - **D.** Send the feedback in writing to the whole team so everyone learns
4. In A.R.T., adapted to a team member, what happens at Reframe?
   - **A.** You explain the rule again in more detail
   - **B.** You offer a smaller concession so the person feels heard
   - **C.** You shift from what they want changed to what changing it would cost
   - **D.** You ask whether they will accept the standard
5. A team member pushes back a second time on a boundary you can hold. What do you do?
   - **A.** Escalate the tone so they know you mean it
   - **B.** Meet them halfway to protect the relationship
   - **C.** End the conversation and say no more about it
   - **D.** Hold the same three steps again, calmly, and restate the boundary plainly

Upskill Challenge

Before your next practice, choose one of the two tracks.

If you hold the Assistant Manager title: pick a real commitment from this week and set it using all four parts, in writing. Run one SBI conversation on a genuine missed commitment within two days of the event. Run one A.R.T. chain where someone asks for an exception, and write down the exact words you used at Reframe and Transition. Hold the boundary through the first push.

If you do not yet hold the title: pick a peer task you are already part of. Set one expectation using all four parts. Give one SBI piece of feedback on something you both saw. Use A.R.T. once with a colleague who wants a shortcut you do not think is right.

Then reflect in five lines: What was hardest? Which step did you skip under pressure? What did the other person do after you held the line? Bring those five lines to your next practice, with Day 2's closing routine, so what you learned becomes part of your day.

> **NOTES**
>
> The hardest moment is the pause after Transition. A person often needs a few seconds to move. Do not fill it by softening the boundary.

Model Answers

Examples, not scripts. Yours should sound like you.

1. "The stock count was due Monday and it is Wednesday. The proposal goes out Friday, and your count tells me which lines I can promise. What happened your side?" Then agree a new time, and ask: "What would you need to see to have it with me before Friday morning?" If the answer shows the count is too heavy, keep your own deadline and split the count with them.

2. "Nothing on your mind still counts as an answer. I have noticed that two tasks are taking longer than expected." Then wait. If the silence holds, ask: "What is taking more effort than it should?" A one-to-one that survives eight seconds of silence is usually the one that finds the problem.

3. Acknowledge: "I hear you; the customer is waiting and it feels like the check is the only thing in the way." Reframe: "The check exists to stop a defect reaching the customer, and if it goes wrong it lands on the customer and on us both." Transition: "What can we do right now to give the customer a reliable date without changing the check?" If the request touches something outside your authority, escalate early with your recommendation. Escalating is a strength, not a failure.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. All four parts, including what to do if it slips, are needed; the slip instruction is what makes early reporting easy.
- 2. C. Reporting early is the behavior you want, so reward it by getting the facts and agreeing the fix, even when the news is late.
- 3. A. SBI describes the specific situation, the observable behavior and the impact, then has the person practice the next behavior.
- 4. C. Reframe moves the decision criterion from the demand to the cost of changing, without re-explaining the rule or giving ground.

- 5. D. Repeating the same chain holds the boundary without escalating, trading, or going quiet.

References

Center for Creative Leadership (CCL). SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) feedback model. Center for Creative Leadership.

Covey, S. R. (1989). The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People. Free Press.

Guyer, J. J., Fabrigar, L. R., & Vaughan-Johnston, T. I. (2019). Speech rate, intonation, and pitch: Investigating the bias and cue effects of vocal confidence on persuasion. Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 45(3), 389–405.

Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli. Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428.

Saad, S. A.R.T.: Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition. MEDJAY.

Voss, C., & Raz, T. (2016). Never Split the Difference: Negotiating As If Your Life Depended On It. Harper Business.